



The Quiet Vale

Seasons of Settlement

Playtester Rulebook

A focused table reference for learning and blind playtesting.

Copyright (C) 2026 Robert Little. All rights reserved.

www.thequietvalegame.com

Welcome To The Vale

The banners of war have long since fallen silent.

Across the Quiet Vale, roads once marched by armies now welcome traders, settlers, and wandering folk searching for somewhere safe to begin again.

You were once part of that older age: a scout, knight, scholar, healer, wanderer, or steward whose years of hardship now give way to rebuilding.

Across three changing Seasons, you will gather resources, expand a shared settlement, welcome new Arrivals, and overcome the Burdens left behind by a fractured world.

The Quiet Vale is not a game about conquest. It is a game about stewardship, resilience, and building a place that may endure.

How To Use This Playtest Guide

This is a trimmed table reference for learning the game. It keeps the core flow, costs, timing, and card handling rules players need during a playtest. The fuller production rulebook can keep the deeper wording and edge-case lists.

USE CARD TEXT

When a card gives a specific exception, use the card. This guide explains the normal rules and avoids listing every card-specific fallback.

Game Overview

The Quiet Vale is a cooperative tile-laying and settlement-building game for 1-4 players. The group builds a shared settlement across three Seasons, manages a shared Warehouse, reveals Encounters, welcomes Arrivals, and prevents Strain from disabling important tiles.

- Build and upgrade a shared settlement.
- Gather and spend shared resources from the Warehouse.
- Seed hidden Encounter Cards at the start of each Season.
- Complete Arrivals to unlock Special Tiles.
- Resolve or endure Burdens before Strain becomes too costly.

Setup

1. Lay out the Game Map, Stewards Board, Warehouse Board, and Round Timer.
2. Each player chooses a unique Steward and takes that Steward's Player Aid and Steward House Tile.
3. Set the shared Warehouse using the player-count table.
4. Build the balanced Encounter pool, deal 9 hidden Encounter Cards to each player, and deal 6 standard Encounter Cards per player to the Encounter Deck. Golden Boons are not currently supported by the online prototype.
5. Each player places their Steward House for free on its setup terrain. This costs 0 Actions and 0 resources, ignores normal adjacency, and must use an empty non-River hex.

6. Begin Round 1 with Seasonal Seed Encounter Cards. Each player seeds one card to the Top, one to the Middle, and one to the Bottom. There is no forced opening Resource tile; players choose their first normal tile action.

Starting Warehouse

Players	1	2	3	4
Starting Warehouse	15 each	10 each	5 each	0 each

Steward House Setup

Steward	Free setup House placement	First normal tile
Vanguard	Vanguard House on Woodland.	Player choice.
Knight	Knight House on Arable Land.	Player choice.
Sentinel	Sentinel House on Mountains.	Player choice.
Ranger	Ranger House on Heaths.	Player choice.
Warden	Warden House on Ruins.	Player choice.
Quartermaster	Quartermaster House on Woodland, Mountains, Heaths, Arable Land, or Ruins. Not Grasslands or River.	Player choice.
WHY HOUSES MATTER A basic Steward House is a normal placed Housing tile. Its upgraded Home unlocks that Steward's once-per-Season power. Only the matching Steward may use their own Steward Power.		

Encounter Setup

Players	Boons	Burdens	Arrivals	Golden Boons	Hidden Cards	Deck Cards
1	5	5	5	0 - not supported online	9	6 standard
2	10	10	10	0 - not supported online	9 each	12 standard
3	15	15	15	0 - not supported online	9 each	18 standard
4	20	20	20	0 - not supported online	9 each	24 standard
ONLINE PROTOTYPE NOTE Golden Boons are excluded from the current online prototype and should not be added during online playtests.						

Round Structure

The game lasts 15 rounds across three Seasons. Rounds 1, 6, and 11 begin with Seasonal Seed Encounter Cards. All other rounds skip seeding and begin with Reveal Encounters.

Season	Rounds	Focus
Season I - Foundations	1-5	Resource production, early routes, and starting infrastructure
Season II - Growth	6-10	Population, Arrivals, travel expansion, industry, and community development
Season III - Maturity	11-15	Resilience, Renown, final refinement, and unresolved settlement pressure
Phase	Name	Summary
1	Seasonal Seed Encounter Cards	Only in Rounds 1, 6, and 11. Each player seeds 3 hidden cards: 1 Top, 1 Middle, and 1 Bottom.
2	Reveal Encounters	Reveal standard Encounter Cards equal to player count. Golden Boons are not used in the online prototype.
3	Player Turns	Each player takes one turn with 4 Actions. The group chooses turn order.
4	End of Round	Remove Arrival timers, expire failed Arrivals, discard applicable Boons, and advance the Round Timer.
SEASONAL SEEDING At the start of each Season, each player seeds 3 hidden cards: one Top, one Middle, and one Bottom. Players do not seed cards during the other rounds.		

Reveal And Actions By Player Count

Player Count	Standard Encounter Cards Revealed per Round	Actions per Player
1	1	4
2	2	4
3	3	4
4	4	4

Player Actions

Action	Summary
Place a Tile	Place an available tile into an empty legal map space.
Upgrade a Tile	Flip a placed basic tile to its upgraded side.
Activate a Tile	Use a tile with an Activated Effect, including Resource Tile Production.
Interact with an Encounter Card	Complete an Arrival or resolve/interact with an active Burden on the Stewards Board.
Travel to a Disconnected Tile	Move beyond the connected settlement network, including unbridged river crossing or disconnected placement.

Players may also spend extra Actions when a tile action requires disconnected Travel or river crossing. The prototype calculates these costs, but players should still understand why they happened.

Map, Tiles, And Reachability

- Tiles stay on the map unless a rule explicitly removes them.
- Placed, non-Overstrained tiles connected by side adjacency form the connected settlement network.
- Stewards share the connected settlement network; one player's placed tiles can extend another player's reach if connected.
- Each player's Steward location is the tile they last interacted with or placed.
- A tile is reachable if it is the Steward's tile or connected to that tile through the connected settlement network.
- Overstrained tiles break the connected settlement network.
- Multi-hex tiles count all hexes in their footprint for adjacency and connection. Single-hex tiles do not need rotation.

Rivers And Bridges

- River hexes are barriers. Tiles do not connect across a river unless a Bridge or card effect allows the crossing.
- Every River hex is a legal potential Bridge placement site.
- Crossing a river without a Bridge connection costs 1 Action when the action requires that crossing.
- A Bridge connects settlement networks through its river hex. An Overstrained Bridge stops providing that connection.

Resources And Warehouse

The Warehouse is shared by all players. It stores Wood, Stone, Metal, Food, Herbs, and Goods. The Warehouse limit is 15 of each resource.

Resource	Common Sources
Wood	Forests
Stone	Mines
Metal	Mines and Dig Sites
Food	Farms, Wildlands, and Forests
Herbs	Wildlands
Goods	Farms, Dig Sites, and Crafting

Steward Houses And Powers

- Steward Houses are placed for free during setup before the first Seasonal Seed Encounter Cards step.
- The acting Steward's marker starts on their own Steward House after setup placement.
- A basic Steward House does not grant its once-per-Season power until upgraded to its Home side.
- Only the matching Steward may use their own upgraded Home power, even though all Stewards may use the shared connected settlement network.
- Using a Steward Power never waives resource costs, placement requirements, or disconnected Travel unless that power says so.

Upgraded Home	Once per Season Steward Power
Vanguard Home	Place a Travel Tile or Resource Tile without spending the Place Action. Costs, requirements, and disconnected Travel still apply.
Knight Home	Place a Housing Tile without spending the Place Action. Costs, requirements, and disconnected Travel still apply.
Sentinel Home	Upgrade a Core Tile without spending the Upgrade Action. Costs, requirements, and disconnected Travel still apply.
Ranger Home	When placing a tile in a disconnected empty hex, ignore the extra disconnected Travel Action for that placement.
Quartermaster Home	Exchange up to 3 Warehouse resources for the same number of different non-Goods resources.
Warden Home	Resolve an active Burden without spending the Resolve Action. Normal costs and requirements still apply.

Encounter Cards

Encounter Cards are seeded into and revealed from the Encounter Deck. Seasonal seeding happens only in Rounds 1, 6, and 11. Cards on the Stewards Board are open information. Players may inspect active cards, completed Arrivals, active Burdens, and face-up Boons.

Encounter Type	When Revealed
Boon	Resolve the current Season effect. If it modifies a later action or future event, keep it face-up according to its text.
Burden	Apply the current Season effect. Place the card on the Stewards Board as an active Burden.
Arrival	Place it on the Stewards Board with 3 timer tokens. Players may complete it by fulfilling its Requirement and spending an Interact action.
Golden Boon	Not currently supported by the online prototype.

Arrivals And Special Tiles

- An Arrival enters play with 3 timer tokens.
- To complete an Arrival, fulfill its Requirement all at once and spend 1 Action to interact with it.
- Arrival resource Requirements cannot be partly paid over time.
- At the end of each round, each active Arrival loses 1 timer token. If it reaches 0 before completion, it expires.
- A completed Arrival unlocks its Special Tile. Any player may later place that unlocked Special Tile with a normal Place a Tile action.
- Unlocked but unplaced Special Tiles are not on the map and have no effects until placed.

Burdens

- When a Burden is revealed, apply the current Season effect and then place it on the Stewards Board as an active Burden.
- Unresolved active Burdens reapply at the start of Round 6 using Season II text and at the start of Round 11 using Season III text.
- If a Burden places Strain, choose valid tiles with fewer than 3 Strain. If there are fewer valid tiles than requested, choose all valid tiles.
- If no valid target exists, no Strain is placed for that application. The Burden remains active unless resolved.
- Some Season III Burdens include fallback targets or Season III-only resolution. Use the text printed on that card rather than memorising a separate list.
- Resolving a Burden removes it from the Stewards Board and prevents future reapplications. It does not remove Strain already placed.

PLAYTEST FOCUS

Players should notice active Burdens. Leaving them unresolved can create repeated pressure and final score penalties.

Boons And Golden Boons

- When a standard Boon is revealed, apply the effect matching the current Season.
- Boon effects are optional unless the card says otherwise.
- Most Boons resolve immediately and are discarded.
- Boons that affect the next or first eligible action stay face-up until used, then are discarded. If unused, discard them in Phase Four unless the card says to keep it face-up.
- Golden Boons are not currently supported by the online prototype, so do not add them for online blind tests.

Strain, Supported, And Overstrained

Strain represents pressure on the settlement: damage, exhaustion, unstable resources, and unresolved social harm.

- A tile cannot have more than 3 Strain.
- A tile with 3 Strain is Overstrained.
- Tiles with 1 or 2 Strain still function unless a rule says otherwise.
- Supported prevents the first Strain token applied to that tile each round.
- Supported does not stack. Multiple sources still prevent only the first Strain that round.
- Overstrained tiles cannot be activated or upgraded, provide no passive effects, do not score, and do not contribute to reachability.
- As soon as a tile has fewer than 3 Strain, it is no longer Overstrained.

Season Ends And Final Scoring

Season End	Timing	Effect
End of Season I	After Round 5	Add up to 10 assorted resources to the Warehouse. The 15-per-type Warehouse limit still applies.
End of Season II	After Round 10	Each Overstrained tile spreads 1 Strain to an adjacent tile, following normal Strain cap and prevention rules.
End of Season III	After Round 15	Apply final Renown penalties: -6 Renown for each active Burden and -2 Renown for each Strain token on the board.

- Add Population from non-Overstrained placed tiles.
- Add Renown from non-Overstrained placed tiles.
- Subtract 6 Renown for each unresolved active Burden.
- Subtract 2 Renown for each Strain token on the board.

FINAL SCORE

Population + Renown - active Burden penalties - Strain penalties.

Quick Glossary

Term	Definition
Active Arrival	An Arrival on the Stewards Board with timer tokens whose Requirement has not yet been fulfilled.
Active Burden	A Burden on the Stewards Board that has not been resolved or otherwise removed.
Activated Effect	A tile effect used by spending an Activate a Tile action. The activated tile must be reachable and not Overstrained unless a rule says otherwise.
Boon	A standard Encounter type that resolves a Season-specific benefit. Golden Boons are not standard Boons.
Burden	An ongoing negative Encounter type that applies Season-specific pressure and remains active until resolved or removed.
Completed Arrival	An Arrival whose Requirement has been fulfilled and whose unlocked Special Tile has not yet been placed. It is not active.
Encounter Card	A card of one Encounter type: Boon, Burden, Arrival, or Golden Boon.
Golden Boon	A distinct Encounter type. Exactly one is used per game. It may break normal rules in card-specific ways.
Internal Role Tag	A production/development label used for organisation. It has no rules meaning unless printed rules text explicitly says otherwise.
Multi-Hex Tile	A tile that occupies more than one hex. It counts as one placed tile and must cover empty, legal hexes when placed.
Overstrained	A tile with 3 Strain. It is inactive for functional checks and positive settlement value.
Passive	A non-action effect that applies while its condition is true. Passive effects stop applying while the tile is Overstrained unless a rule says otherwise.
Production	The resource-generating Activated Effect found on Resource Tiles.
Reachable Tile	A tile the acting Steward can use from their current position through the connected settlement network, unless a rule says otherwise.
Special Tile	A tile unlocked through an Arrival. It has no resource cost by default and is placed later with a Place Tile action.
Steward Power	A limited-use effect on an upgraded Steward House. It is not an Activated Effect and does not require activating the tile.
Supported	A persistent status that prevents the first Strain token applied to a tile each round.
Warehouse	The shared resource store for all players.
Connected Settlement Network	All placed, non-Overstrained tiles connected by side adjacency, excluding blocked river crossings or other barriers unless an explicit rule connects across them.
River Barrier	A river or water feature that blocks normal adjacency for connectivity. Crossing normally requires a Bridge or a Travel to a Disconnected Tile action.
Travel Tile	A tile category representing movement infrastructure, river crossing, support, separated-cluster connection, resilience, or scoring. Travel Tiles are no longer the only tiles that carry reachability.

Playtest Notes

- Use this guide to learn and play. Use the cards themselves for exact one-off card rules.
- If a rule feels unclear, note what happened, the round, the card or tile involved, and what the group expected.
- The most useful feedback is about pacing, tension, choices, resource pressure, and whether the settlement story is coming through.

OWNERSHIP

The Quiet Vale(TM): Seasons of Settlement and all prototype rulebook materials are (C) Robert Little. All rights reserved. Shared for private playtesting and review.